the amount of aid appropriated for India was less than the previous year. From then on, this would be the rule rather than the exception.

At that stage, however, the overall prospects of US-India relations seemed good. Nehru conveyed his country's gratitude for America's "friendly and sympathetic attitude, even more than the aid" and emphasized that it would persist no matter what differences emerged.[191] And American officials in Delhi noted the definite "[m]ovement of India toward [the] West during [the] past five years."[192] As NSC staffer Robert Komer would later note, China had made—and would continue to make—a significant contribution to that movement.

"Growls from Peking"

By 1961, Nehru was convinced that Beijing was the real danger to peace and to a US-Soviet détente. Moreover, he told Chester Bowles, now under secretary of state, that the border situation with China was dangerous in the northeast, with Beijing refusing to negotiate. He feared that China's domestic economic challenges would only increase Beijing's assertiveness. Nonetheless, while Nehru believed Beijing would "press forward wherever possible," he did not expect that China would resort to "any massive military moves" during Mao's lifetime.

Bowles told Nehru that the possibility of major Chinese aggression in the next decade could not be ruled out. He urged that India and the US discuss such a contingency, even if they could not jointly plan for it. He noted that in the long term an Asian power balance—with India, Japan, and Pakistan—could help contain China, with the US military "more unobtrusively in the background." In the meantime, he assured Nehru that "if China sought to expand into South or Southeast Asia by military power we would oppose this effort with whatever allies we could persuade to cooperate with us."[193]

He was not the only American policymaker worried on this score. In August, meeting with the Taiwanese vice president, Kennedy outlined American uncertainty about China's overall intentions and actions. He particularly cited the Sino-Indian border dispute as a potential point of concern over the next year.[194]

The China-Pakistan Relationship